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130 Game On



148 Everything
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Efforts are underway to enable you to learn Indian languages on your cell phone

Samir Makwana

The mobile phone, a tool originally intended for just communication, has gone beyond the basics—it is now used for entertainment and commerce as well. It's the case of a single device enabling a lot of things. Mobile content such as screensavers, mobile games, and other applications are being offered for entertainment as well as edutainment.

Even newspapers can be read on a mobile phone: recently, Pressmart and IMI Mobile announced the availability of mPaper (mobile newspaper) for nine Indian dailies on the mobile phone. Pressmart, a subsidiary of Bodhitree Consulting Ltd, is a digital media delivery partner of leading newspapers and magazines. IMI Mobile is an end-to-end Value Added Services enabler.

Besides this, *Kalnirnay*—a calendar, almanac, recipe-book, and a source of other useful information in seven languages, is now being made available on the mobile phones by Enable M, a mobile content and services provider company. And now, mobile content aggregators are developing educational content as well.

Where It Began

At the Reliance Mobile Application Contest in February 2005-06, an application called *TeachMe Hindi* bagged the second prize in the corporate category. TeachMe Hindi was developed by Jayadev Gopalakrishnan, CEO, and Anupam Varghese, CTO, of Tinfo Mobile Pvt Ltd. This award came on the heels of their earlier award for developing an application called "All-Minder", an application for the visually impaired to hear SMSes and missed calls, at the Reliance Mobile Application Contest 2004-05.

The *TeachMe Akshara* series consists of a number of applications under the "TeachMe" head for different vernacular languages (presently, Hindi and Malayalam). TeachMe Hindi is the Hindi language module from the TeachMe Akshara series. The application helps

the user read and write letters in Hindi and Malayalam. The letters of the language come up on the screen, and one can know about how the alphabet is pronounced and written.

"TeachMe Akshara was developed to teach illiterates or semi-literates about the vernacular languages of India. Though TeachMe Akshara was meant to teach only basic letters, we consulted language teachers for formulating and verifying the content," says Gopalakrishnan. TeachMe Akshara happens to be the first vernacular language teaching application for mobile phones. An animation of the letter, along with a picture, appears on the phone's screen when a particular letter is selected.

The majority of the Indian population lives in rural areas, and the penetration of the mobile phone have been good. The application is appropriately targeted towards the rural and semi-urban population.

In January 2007, Enable M Mobile Technologies Pvt Ltd, a mobile content and services provider and mobile value

